

CAPSTONE PROJECT

Cooking Quest - Indian Food Hidden Object Game for iPad

Explanatory Research

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introduction

About HOGs

What Is A Hidden Object Game?

“Wikipedia:

A **hidden object game** (sometimes called **hidden picture**) is a genre of puzzle video **game** in which the player must find items from a list that are **hidden** within a picture. **Hidden object games** are a popular trend in casual gaming.”

There are multiple ways to know which item you are supposed to spot - in some games you are actually presented with how the item looks like, other games only show you the silhouette and others just give you a textual description or a name.

Finally, many hidden object games also incorporate other genres - for example some are semi-quests in which objects you find are then added to the inventory as quest items.

Why A Hidden Object Game?

When it comes to playing video games, I'm relatively a newbie. I have very minimal knowledge about the types of games out there. The day I was introduced to Hidden Object Games during my undergrad days, I fell totally and inevitably in love with the puzzles, mini games and the ability to search every room for items in order to progress to another room.

The part where I am in a maze of twisty little passages and when I have to figure out ways of getting out of the obstacles, opened up my eyes to explore this field further.

After playing the Big Fish game "Cooking Quest" in 2008 (which was big back then), I always waited for them to come up with a sequel like their Mystery Case and Nancy Drew collection.

Today, for my capstone project I have decided the best idea would be to make the sequel instead of waiting for years of more disappointment that the next part has not been created.

Timeline

History Of Hidden Object Games

Hidden object games are a big part of the success that the casual games industry is seeing today. The genre has especially been defined and moved forward by the series of Mystery Case Files games that has seen over 100 million downloads worldwide.

When the original Mystery Case Files: Huntsville game was launched, there weren't any hidden object games in the market. The inspiration came from all the Where's Waldo and I-Spy books where the traditional hidden object game was made an interactive experience.

In 2005, Adrian Woods, (game designer/developer at Big Fish), Bill Meyer (game artist at Big Fish) and Patrick Wylie (VP at Big Fish) came onboard at Big Fish, and Adrian started working on a game he called Scavenger Hunt. Later they realized that it would be cool to add some mystery to it, inspired by Cold Case Files (a legal reality show that documents the investigation of unsolved crimes). The player would be solving a mystery, which would help to build a supporting narrative behind the game.

Huntsville was the first hidden object game that Big Fish Studios developed. There had been other hidden object games around in the market, but they were not formally called hidden object games, and were targeted at kids

History Of Hidden Object Games

When hidden object games started, the rhythm of gameplay was hidden object scene, then puzzle. Now the flow is story, navigation through world, hidden object scene, puzzle, navigation scene, etc.

In the next Mystery Case Files, called Prime Suspect, more characters were added, more mini-games and puzzles to break up the hidden object scenes, and that went really well. Then in December 2006 came Ravenhearst, and it was an even bigger success. Adrian had wanted to put a bigger story into it, so he created Charles Dalimar and Emma Ravenhearst, the residents of Ravenhearst Manor. Bill and Adrian also came up with the idea of creating intricate puzzles inspired by Rube Goldberg machines. They were fantastically humorous and very difficult, almost too difficult, especially since there weren't any hints.

There are a lot of interesting new developments in the hidden object games coming out these days. The story is still a big part of the games, and some of the new games totally immerse you into a universe, and I think many things can still be done here.

The future of hidden object games is also tightly connected to the platform and format, too. The next generations of hidden object games are going to be impacted by the opportunities on the mobile platform, but most definitely also by the free-to-play trend that we are seeing.

Explanation

Types Of Hidden Object Games

Hidden object games may seem awful straightforward. You find objects that are hidden into drawn scenes. Simple, right? Well, it turns out there is as much variety to the types of hidden object games that are usually grouped in the following subcategories:

- ❖ **HO/HOG** - Hidden Object Game (the classic HO with word lists)
- ❖ **AHOG** - Adventure-Hidden Object Game
- ❖ **iHOG** - Interactive HOG (HOs that you can interact with, has more adventure aspects)
- ❖ **FrOG** - FRagmented Object Game (find item pieces instead of words on lists and/or Find pieces of items to make a whole object, which you will then use in the game)
- ❖ **HOPA** - Hidden Object Puzzle Adventure (heavier on puzzles and adventure elements mostly point-and-click adventures)

Hidden Object Game Options

When a hidden object game is opened, several options are available. Some games comprise of only one or a few of the options, while others encompass the whole list.

- ❖ **Timed:** timed game where players have to complete a task in a limited time.
- ❖ **UnTimed:** players can take all the time to complete objectives.
- ❖ **Lists:** generally a list in text to refer to objects hidden required to be found.
- ❖ **Pictures:** usually a silhouette or icon of objects familiar to players to be found.
- ❖ **Find The Differences:** two identical scenes with minor differences where user has to find those missing pieces.
- ❖ **Bubbles:** players have to find a hotspot. Once found, bubbles pop up with pictures of the objects that need to be found.

Famous Hidden Object Game Series

Some of the most famous series of Hidden Object Games are:

- ❖ Dark Dimensions
- ❖ Final Cut
- ❖ Grim Facade
- ❖ Grim Tales
- ❖ Haunted Halls
- ❖ Mystery Case Files
- ❖ Mystery Trackers

Publishers Of Hidden Object Games

- ❖ Artifex Mundi
- ❖ Awen Studio
- ❖ Big Fish Games Studios
- ❖ Blue Tea Games
- ❖ Boomzap Entertainment
- ❖ Codeminion
- ❖ Daily Magic Productions
- ❖ Eipix Entertainment
- ❖ Elephant Games
- ❖ ERS Games
- ❖ Mad Head Games
- ❖ PlayFirst
- ❖ Sandlot Games
- ❖ SpinTop Games
- ❖ Tap It Games
- ❖ Top Evidence Studio

Different Platforms For Hidden Object Games

❖ PC Games

❖ Mac Games

❖ Online Games

❖ iPad & iPhone Games

❖ Android Mobile and Tablet Games

1) The industry

Who's Playing Games?

- ❖ 59% of Americans play games
 - Over 150 million people play games
 - Jumping into stories, swapping gummies, fighting goes, traveling through time, and finding hidden object games
- ❖ Average age of the gamer: 31

Gaming and Gender

- ❖ 48% of gamers are female
- ❖ 52 % of games are male
- ❖ 22% of video game workforce is made up of females
- ❖ 76% game developers are males
- ❖ Ages 35-44 were the biggest spenders for gaming in 2013 - 2015

Stats:

- ❖ 62% of all gamers are adults
- ❖ 68% are above 18 and older
- ❖ Average 2 gamers per household
- ❖ 77% gamers play at least one hour a week
- ❖ 36% play games on their smart phone
- ❖ Most players are male
- ❖ Gaming industry increasing more than 9% per year – exceeding over \$86 billion by 2016
- ❖ Japan and China lead gaming on iPhone and iPad
- ❖ 91% people on earth have a mobile phone – 56% own smart phone
- ❖ 80% of time on mobile is spent inside apps or games

Other Stats:

- ❖ Consumers spent 20.77 billion dollars on video games, hardware and accessories in 2012. In 2014, this number is predicted to be \$24 billion.
- ❖ 40% of game sales included digital content, subscriptions, apps and mobile games
- ❖ 120,000 people are employed in the video game industry across 34 states
- ❖ 43% of tablet owners spend more time with their tablets than their TVs or PCs, and 84% of tablet owners spend most of their time playing games on it.

Asia; A Gaming Hub



China saw a 34% increase in games revenue in 2012, and online gaming made up a whopping 94% of the pie. One interesting difference is that the landscape is dominated by social games that involve both cooperation and stealing items or resources from friends.

In Japan there is still quite a lot of arcade play of titles like Pachinko and mobile is extremely popular due to long commutes by train.

Top 10 Gaming Trends and Facts:

1. Women are playing more and more games, and so is the older generation.
2. Gaming families and friend networks are the norm.
3. Revenue from games and game content is up and on par with the movie industry.
4. Games are going more and more mobile.
5. Casual, casino, mobile and social games are becoming as popular as other PC and console games.
6. Free to play business models have redefined the marketplace.
7. Video game violence is more of a problem for the media than for gamers or their families.
8. Variety is the spice of life.
9. Asia is still the hotbed for gaming
10. The only thing that is ever guaranteed is more change.

Reasons Why HOGs Make Sense As Well As Deliver Fun

- ❖ Look beyond initial impressions:
 - Player needs to look beyond obvious and look more closely at the predominant images.
- ❖ Consider the odd:
 - Clues can be challenging with multiple meanings to words such as “bat” or “shell” and etc.
- ❖ Decipher the clues:
 - Some clues take two stages to successfully solve a HOG. The two-step problem solving engages both thinking and visual skills
- ❖ Use of all your skills:
 - Many HOGs include other types of puzzles between hidden object scenes; hidden-pair matching, match tree, jigsaw puzzles, side by side images (minor differences) and word finder.

Reasons Why HOGs Make Sense As Well As Deliver Fun (contd)

❖ Carry your tools with you:

➤ Requires finding items in one scene to use to solve problems in other scenes.

❖ Learn as you play:

➤ Main subject contain interesting factoids to help learn more about a topic while playing.

❖ Cultivate your focus:

➤ HOGs require attention to detail and a focus on the task at hand; helping to cultivate and improve levels of skills in other aspects of day-to-day living.

❖ Practice is key:

➤ Critical thinking skills grow with practice and HOGs help provide an opportunity to practice through play. HOGs can help when you are looking for your keys or something else you've mislaid.

2) User Research

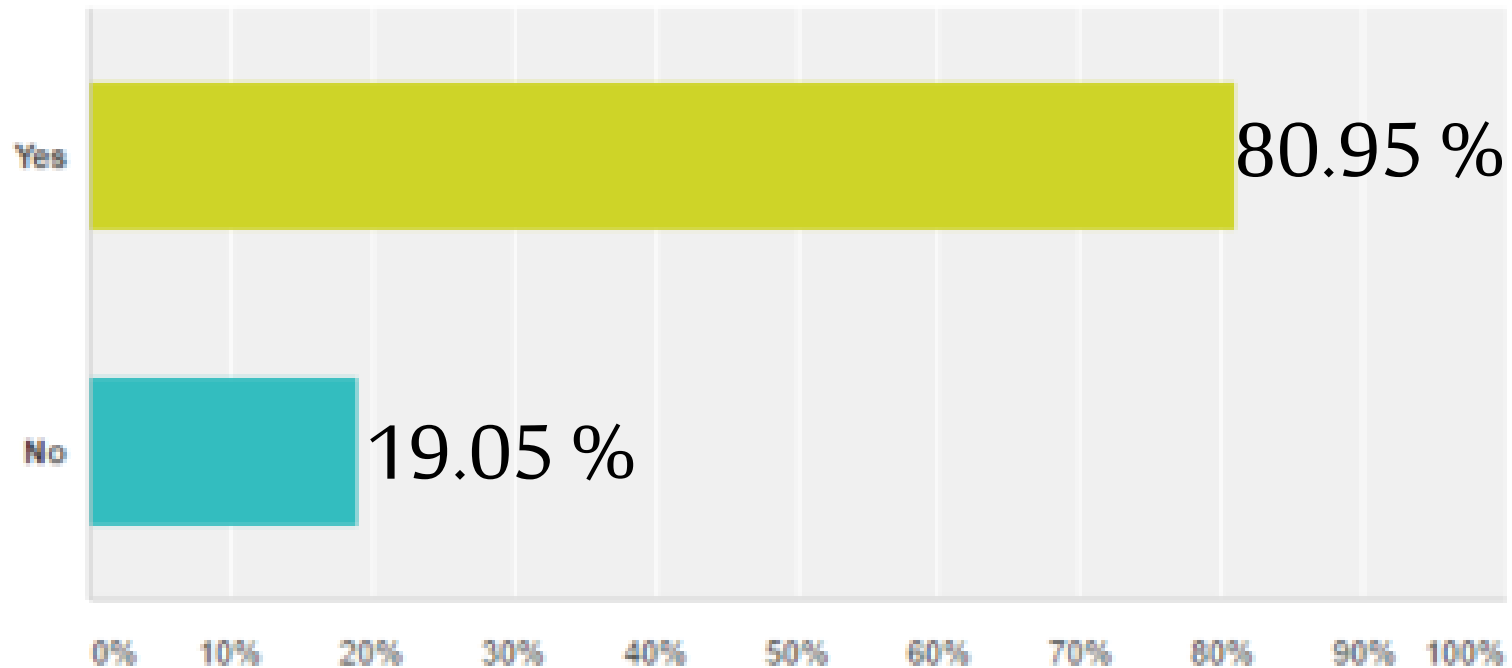
Survey with 129 people

List of questions asked for the survey:

1. Have you ever played a hidden object game?
2. How many hidden object games do you play in a month?
3. What is your favorite thing about hidden object games?
4. On a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 is not important and 5 is very important; how important is art to you?
5. Please rank the following list according to what you thought would be most likely to entice you to purchase a game.
6. What age group would you consider yourself?
7. Would you play a hidden object game which taught you how to cook?
8. What are your thoughts about a hidden object game on exploring Indian cuisine?
9. What iconic image and what colors come to mind when you think of Indian cooking?
10. How do you feel about hidden object games?

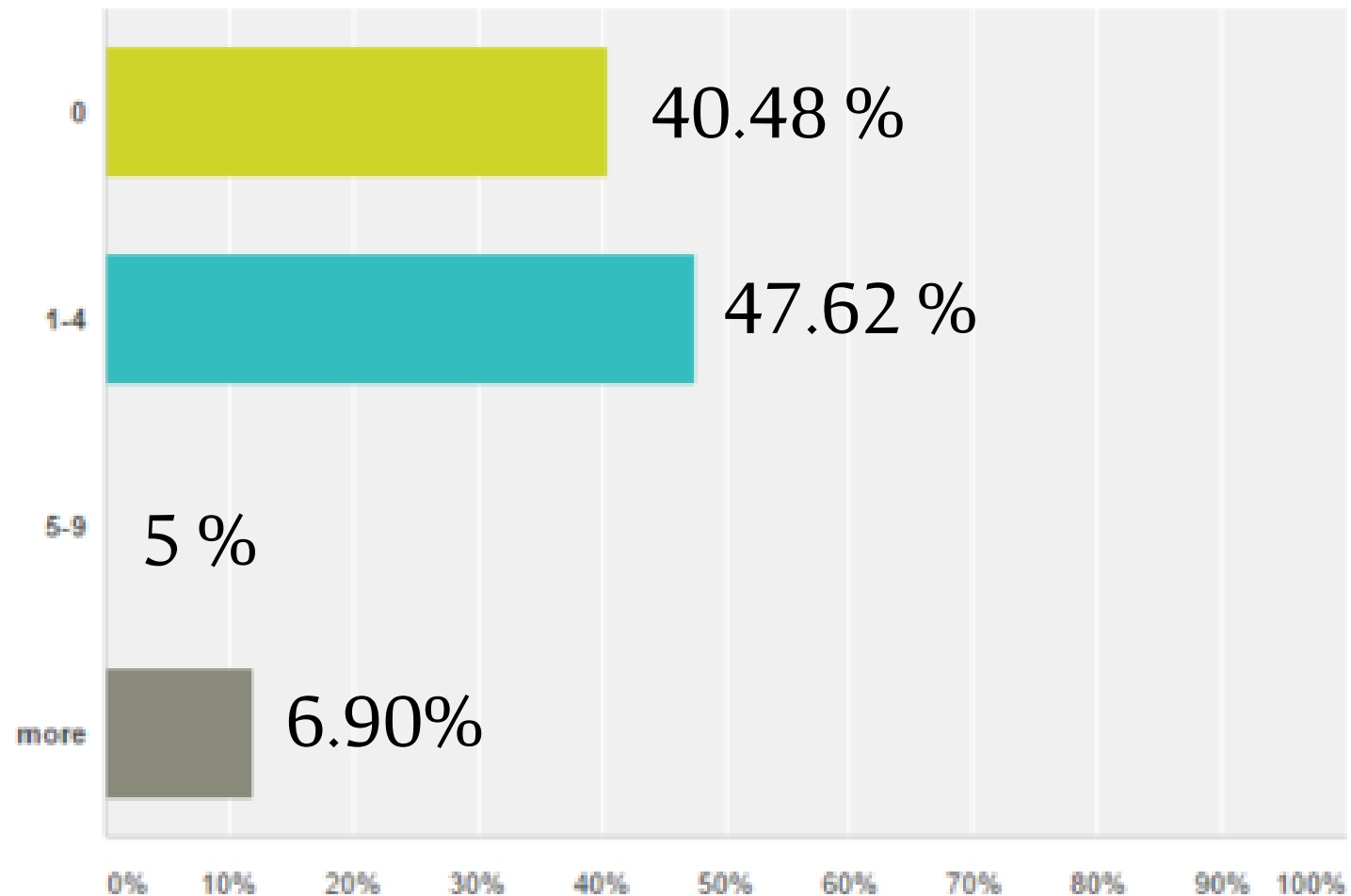
Survey Results

1. Have you ever played a hidden object game?



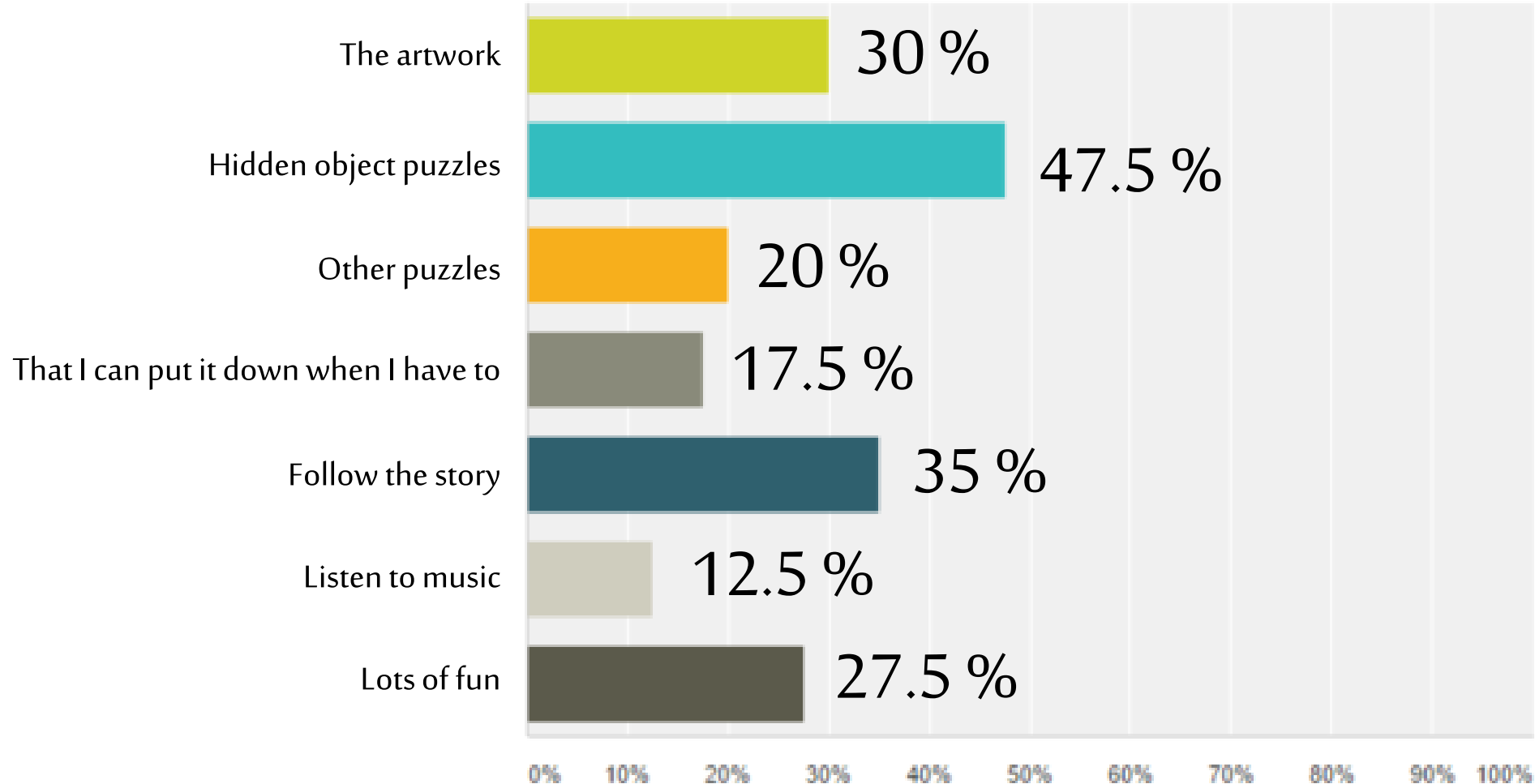
Survey Results

2. How many hidden object games do you play in a month?



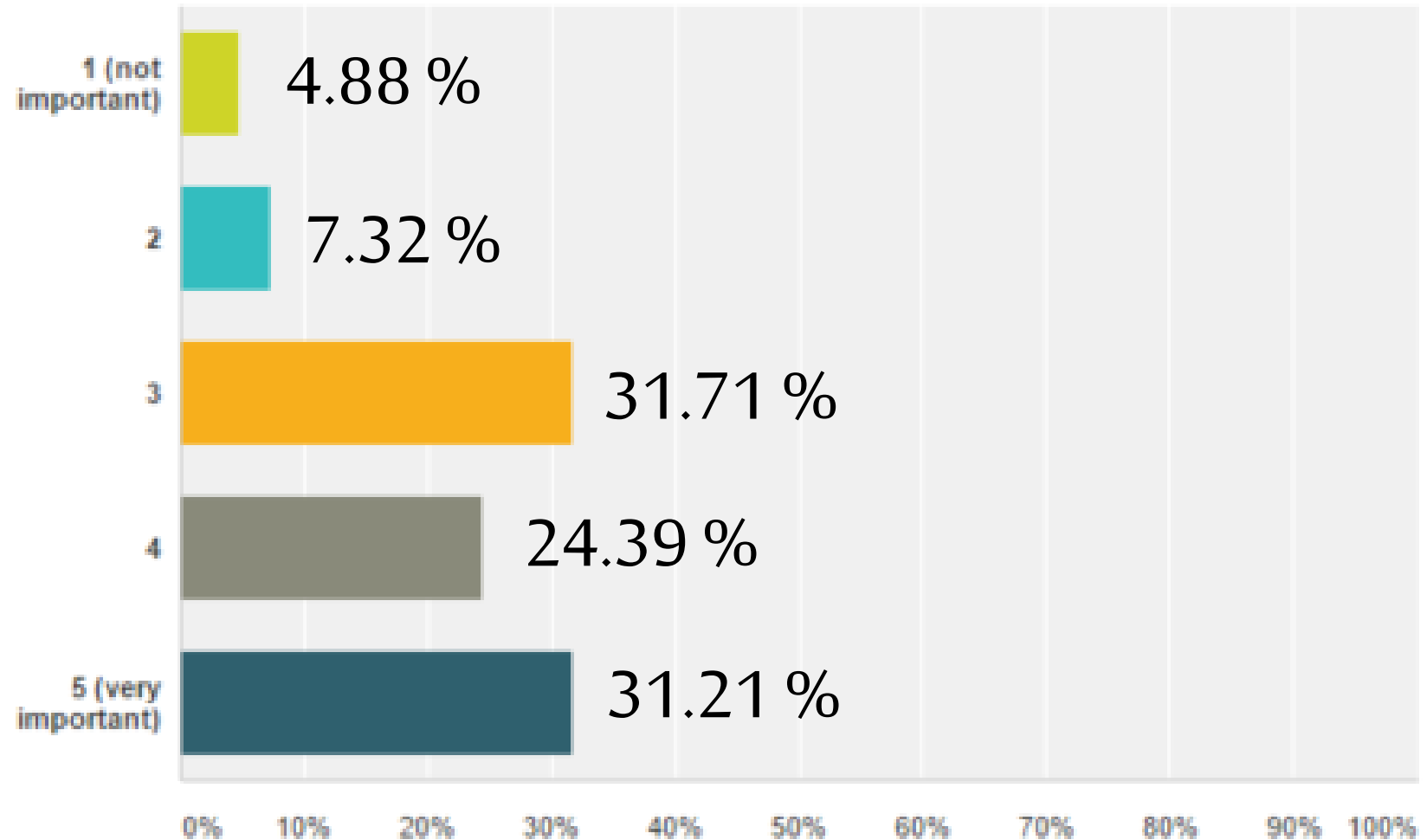
Survey Results

3. What is your favorite thing about hidden object games?



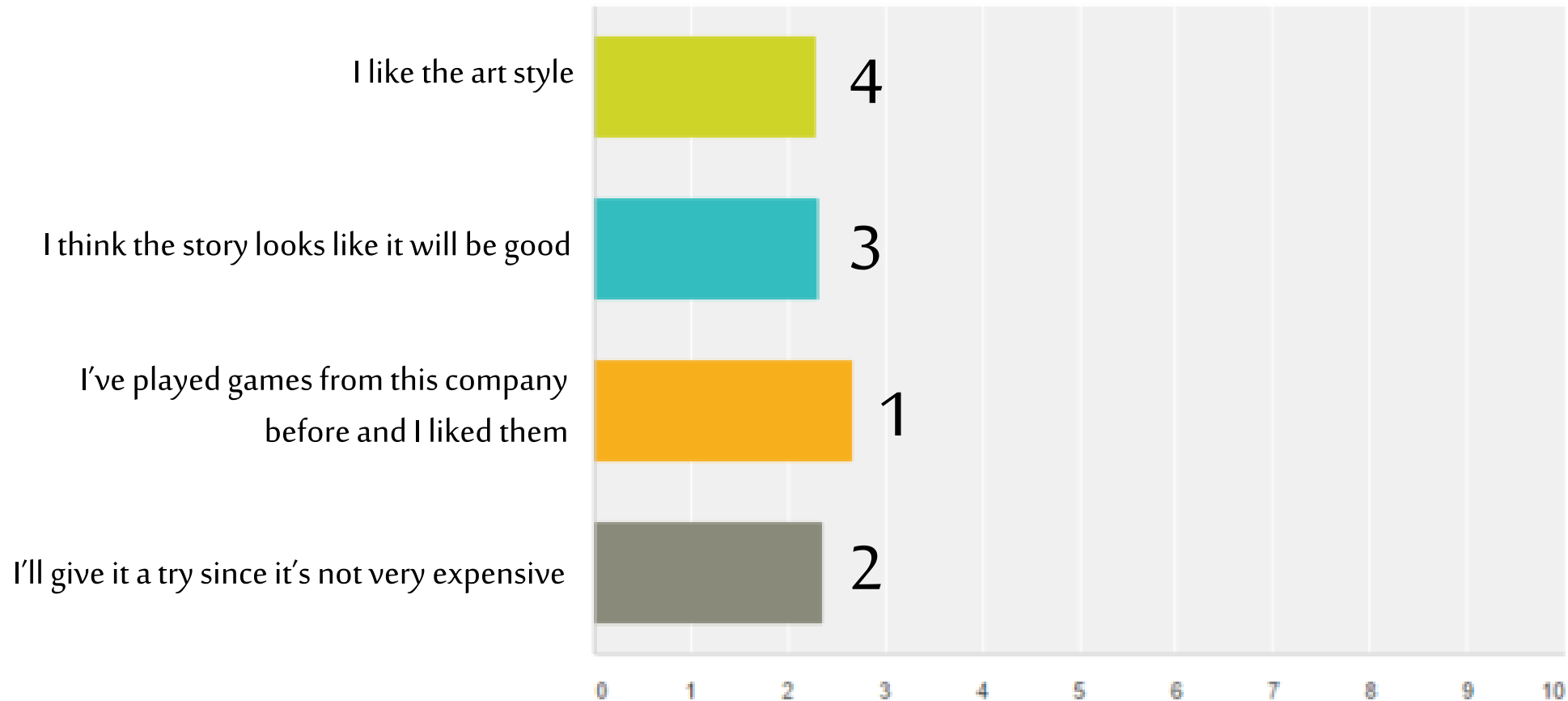
Survey Results

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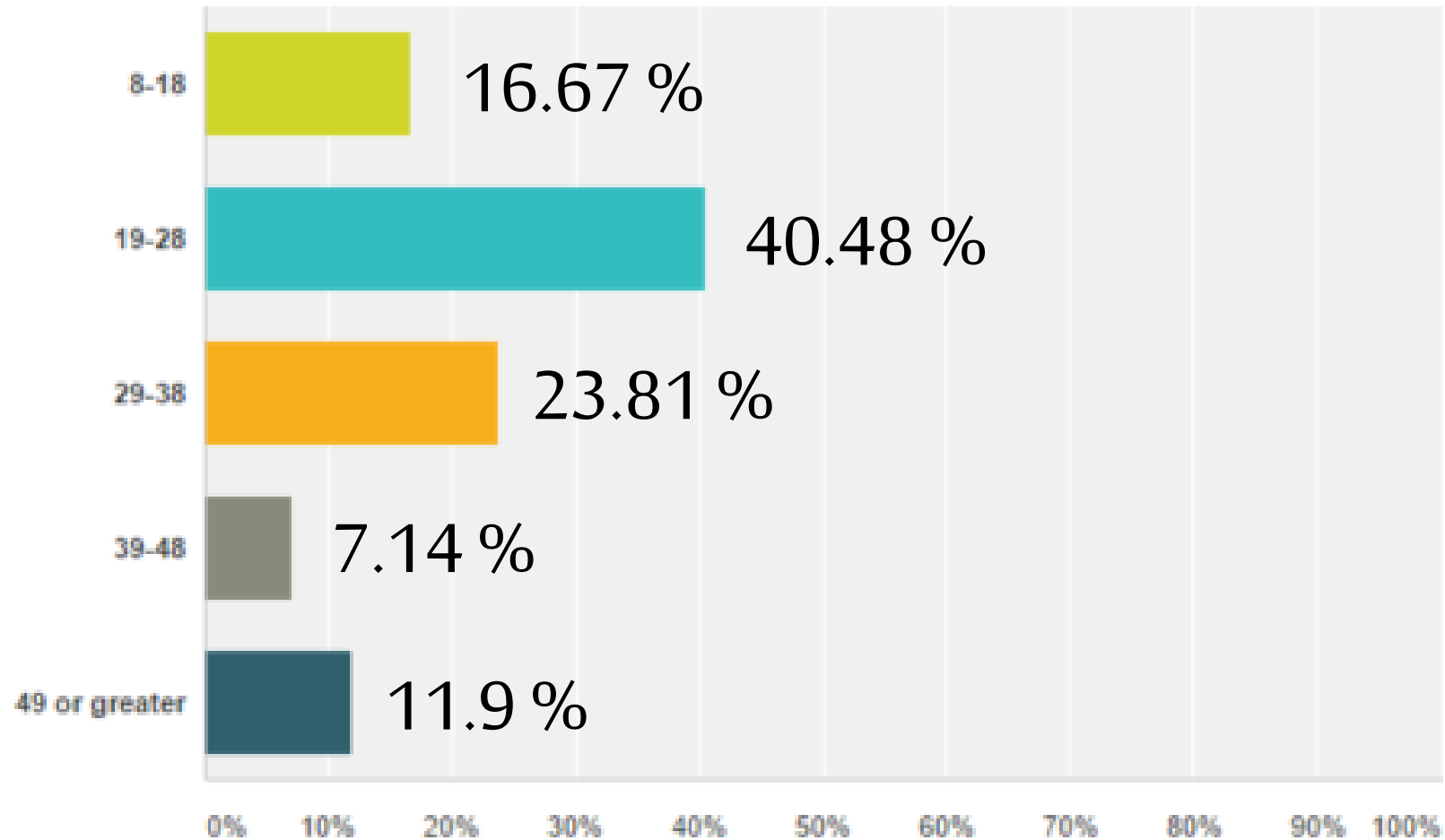
Survey Results

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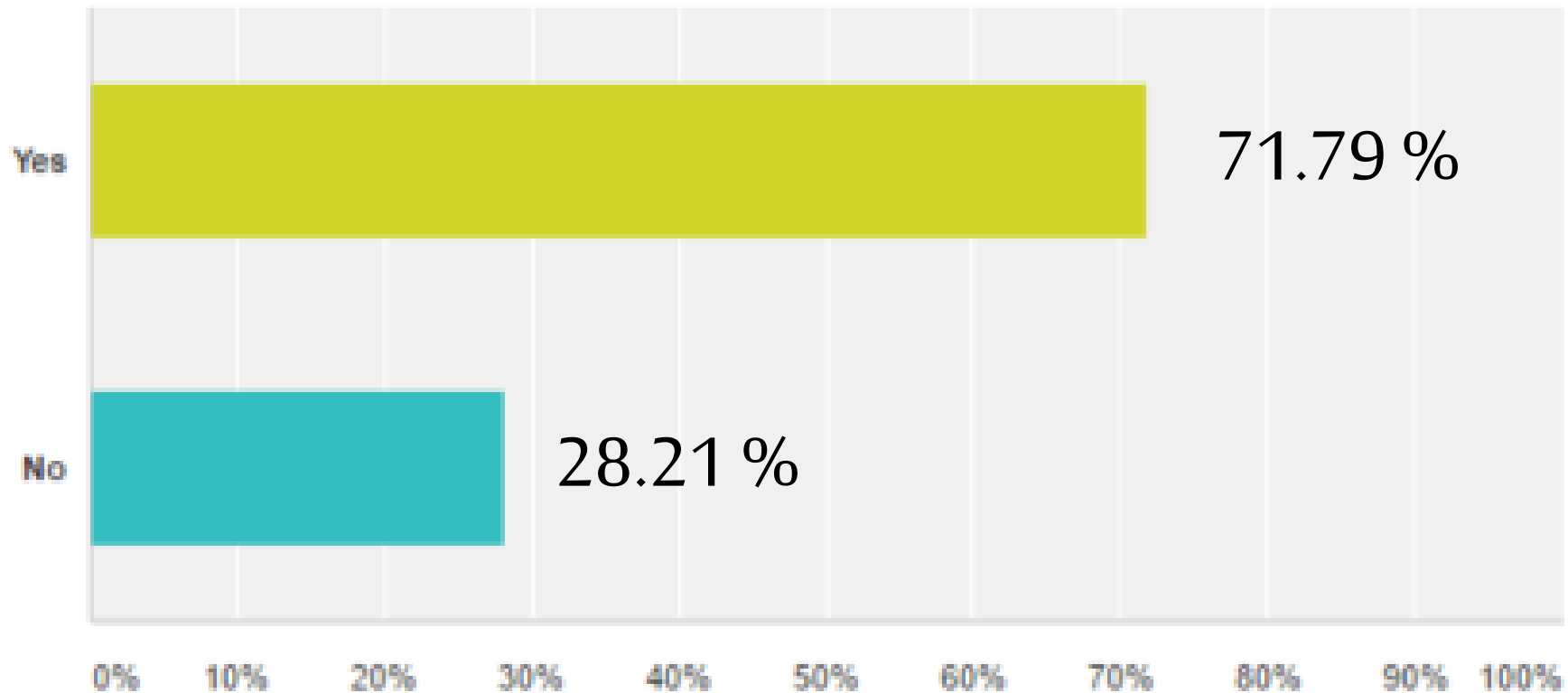
Survey Results

6. What age group would you consider yourself?



Survey Results

7. Would you play a hidden object game which taught you how to cook?



Survey Results

8. What are your thoughts about a hidden object game on exploring indian cuisine?



Survey Results

9. What iconic image and what colors come to mind when you think of indian cooking?

Icons

Variety of curry

Indian Spices

Dosa

Indian Cook

Traditional Dress

Indian Thaali

Turmeric

Desert

Colors

Yellow

Red

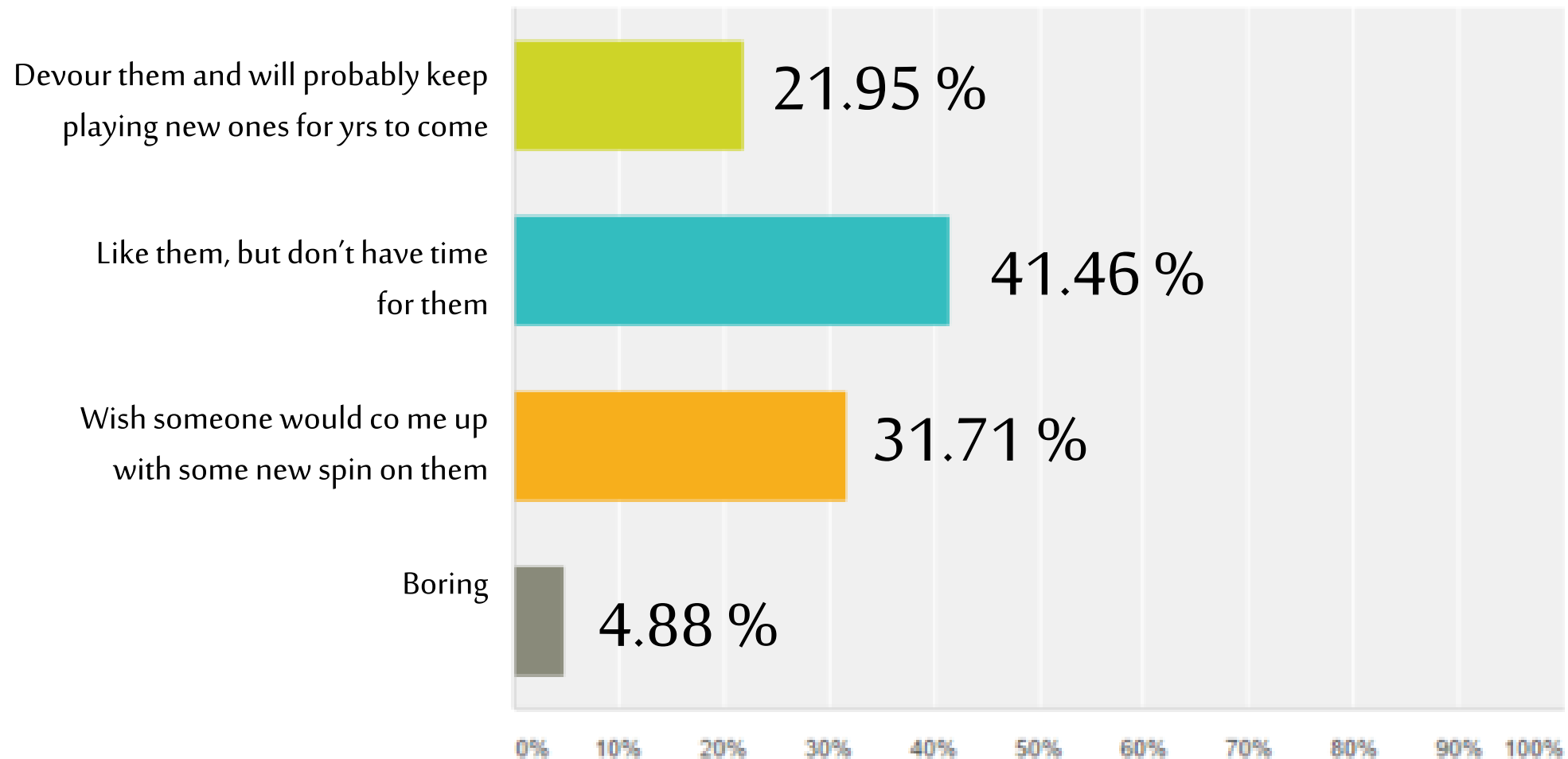
Orange

Brown

Green

Survey Results

10. How do you feel about hidden object games?



3) Competitors

Competitor 1: Perfect Pizza Hidden Objects



A great pizza recipe it's easy to find, but the cooking process it's not as easy as you might think.

This Italian dish it's delicious, especially if you cook it with the best ingredients. You need to make a dough and place freshly cut vegetables and salami on it, as well as a tasty sauce.

Learn what ingredients you need and find them in the kitchen, grocery store and at the market, in our exclusive new game called Perfect Pizza Hidden Objects!

Competitor 2: Cooking Room HOG



Each kitchen of each house has its own little secret. They can lurk anywhere. Only the owners can know that it's the mystery and where they are hidden. To get started, go to the kitchen and look around. Now look more closely, you should see a list of items are in the kitchen. Find the items on the list.

Competitor 3: Go Go Gourmet: Chef of The Year



Ginger is a starry-eyed young chef competing for fame and glory. Join her in a plight to win the celebrated Go Go Gourmet Chef of the Year Contest. Pitted against seven of the world's best chefs, help her sauté her way into 1st place with mouthwatering recipes. Add some spice with up to 21 fashionable cooking outfits! Cook with Go Go Gourmet: Chef of the Year in a Time Management tour of seven countries.

- ❖ Hidden Object/ Time Management sequel
- ❖ Scrumptious mini games
- ❖ Help Ginger reach stardom

Competitor 3: Mystery Cookbook HOG



Mystery Cookbook serves up a sumptuous feast of Hidden Object fun! Scour your screen for cleverly hidden objects, find matching shapes and point out the differences between similar pictures in Mystery Cookbook, a sumptuous feast of Hidden Object fun! Six exciting mini-games are like the cherry on the cake!

- ❖ Six types of mini-games
- ❖ Unique and fun story
- ❖ Great family adventure!



Competitor 4: Cooking Quest (idea came from here)

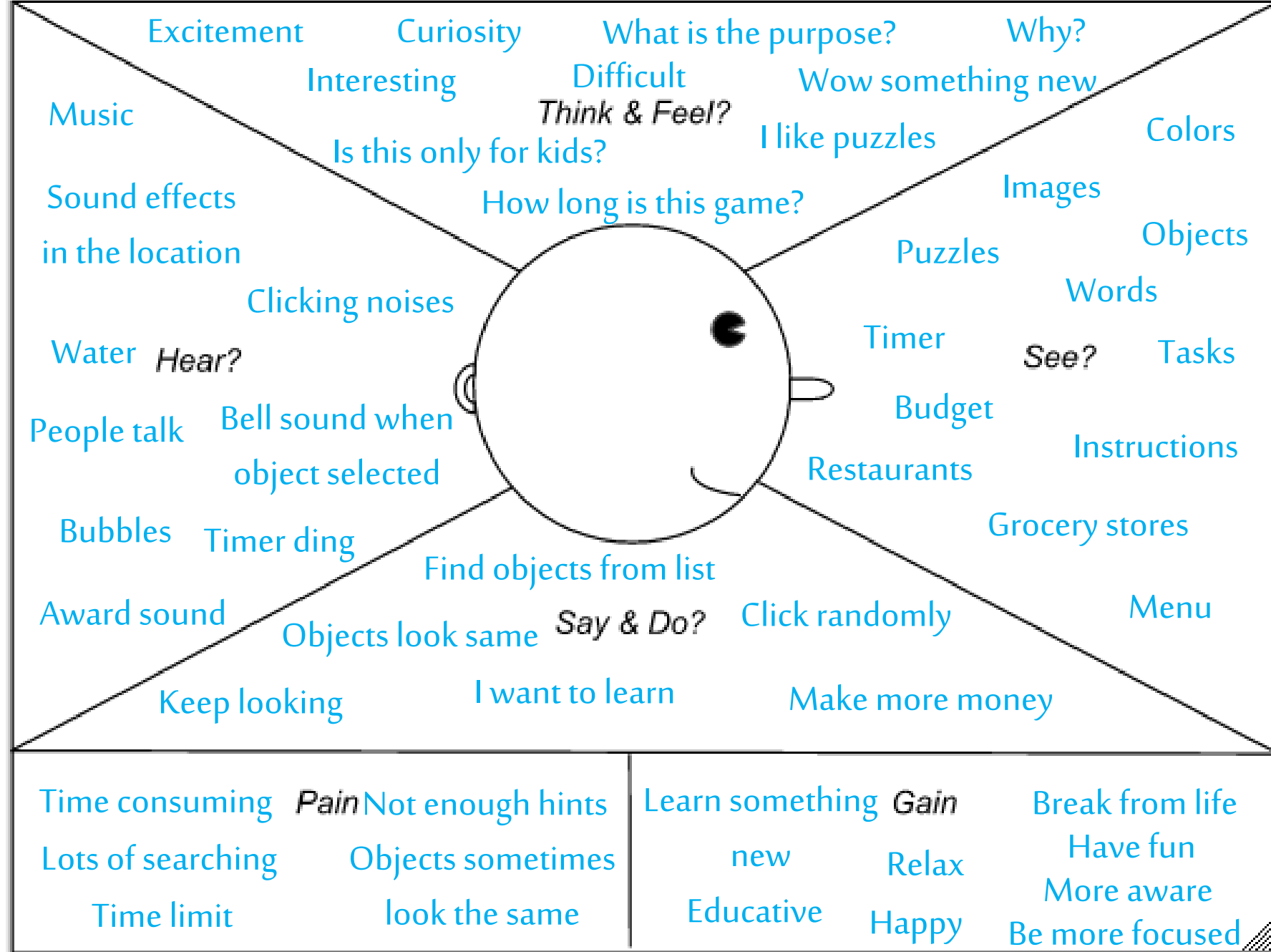


You've been awarded a coveted entry for the Chef's Challenge contest in Foodville's Restaurant Row. Grease the cast-iron skillets as you gather ingredients to smoke the competition away. Manage your budget as you create multi-course gourmet meals in Foodville's most elite restaurants. Can you stand the heat? Start at Chop City Steakhouse on Restaurant Row and find out in Cooking Quest.



- ❖ Zesty Hidden Object game.
- ❖ Replay restaurant levels.
- ❖ Become a master chef.

Empathy Map



Top inSights

Top Insights of HOGs

- ❖ Gaming industry increasing more than 9% per year – exceeding over \$86 billion by 2016
- ❖ Asia is still the hotbed for gaming; Japan and China lead gaming on iPhone and iPad
- ❖ Users find the idea of HOGs very interesting, innovative and educative, yet they do not have enough of time to play them.
- ❖ There are very few HOG games which help in learning to cook different types of food such as Cooking Quest by Big Fish Games.